

The Ones Who Stay

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FADE IN:

1 EXT. STREET - NIGHT 1

Rain taps against pavement in a quiet neighborhood

Two houses sit close together, bedroom windows facing each other across a narrow gap

Thunder rolls in the distance

2 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 2

Unpacked boxes everywhere

A cork board filled with recruiting letters

A football helmet sits on the desk, Star Wars and football posters line the walls

NOAH stands at his window and pulls the blinds halfway down

Across the gap between the houses he sees a light flip on

He stops pulling down the blinds

In the window he sees AVA roll to the window in her wheelchair, oxygen line on her face staring at the rain

She notices Noah, and they make eye contact

Noah gives a half-wave

Ava hesitates, then gives a small wave back

She closes her blinds slowly

Noah stands there a second longer before closing his blinds

Noah turns and walks to his bed to lay down

JULIA (O.S.)

Noah! Did you unpack your football gear? You've got practice tomorrow!

NOAH

Yes Ma'am!

3 INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - MORNING 3

Cloudy outside, Students walking through the halls

Noah is walking down the hall

EMMA sees him and goes over, twirling a strand of her hair

EMMA
Hey, Noah!

NOAH
Hi, Emma.

EMMA
What are you up to later?

NOAH
Football practice, why?

EMMA
Are you busy after? I thought we
could hang out

NOAH
Sorry, I can't

She drops her hair and puts her hand down

EMMA
Oh... okay, no problem

Noah goes to his locker and pulls out his phone

There are multiple unread messages from recruiters

He looks at a few, but doesn't respond

He locks his phone and puts it away

4 EXT. FOOTBALL PRACTICE - EVENING

4

Noah lines up at wide receiver

MASON lines up at corner, across from Noah

MASON
You're slow today

NOAH
You're delusional every day

Quarterback calls for the snap

Noah runs a post-corner route

Mason tries to jam him, but fails

The ball flies through the sky to Noah

He tracks it and catches it in stride

COACH REYNOLDS blows the whistle

COACH REYNOLDS

Again!

Noah jogs to the quarterback and whispers with him

He jogs to the line and runs a post route

Noah loses Mason at his break with a double move

He tracks it again and catches it

Coach Reynolds blows the whistle

COACH REYNOLDS (CONT'D)

That's what I'm talking about!
Separation. You create space and
they can't touch you.

Noah nods

MASON

He only runs that clean because I
let him.

Noah shoves him lightly

NOAH

Scoreboard on Friday's gonna say
otherwise.

BEGIN MONTAGE

-- Noah running routes

-- Dropping a pass

-- Staring at the field, distracted

END MONTAGE

Noah goes to get water, taking off his helmet

Coach Reynolds pulls him aside

COACH REYNOLDS

Recruiters called again.

Noah looks around the field

COACH REYNOLDS (CONT'D)
 You keep this up, you won't be here
 long, kid.

Noah nods

COACH REYNOLDS (CONT'D)
 You love this game, don't you?

NOAH
 Yeah

COACH REYNOLDS
 Good. The second you stop loving
 it, it'll eat you alive.

Noah nods

Coach Reynolds turns around and blows the whistle

Noah jogs back to formation while putting his helmet back on

5 INT. LOCKER ROOM - EVENING

5

Noah is sitting quietly scrolling through his texts with
 recruiters, not smiling

The whole team is joking around and talking loudly

Mason notices Noah being quiet, and goes over to him

MASON
 Noah

Noah doesn't look up, not paying attention

Mason waves in front of his face

MASON (CONT'D)
 Noah

Noah looks up, blinking, trying to focus

NOAH
 Yeah?

MASON
 Bro, you just routed me up all
 practice

NOAH
 So?

MASON
So, you're sitting here like we
just lost the Super Bowl

NOAH
I'm just tired

MASON
Alright, whatever man. Get some rest

Mason leaves

Noah opens a message from a recruiter

RECRUITER (TEXT)
You're exactly what we're looking
for from incoming freshmen

The noise around him gets loud again

6 INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - EVENING

6

Noah is walking through the hall, tired from practice
There's a smaller kid, COLE, head down, hands in his pockets.
TRAVIS comes up to Cole in the hall

TRAVIS
Hey princess. You ever gonna say
anything? Or just stand there.

Cole doesn't respond, keeps walking

TRAVIS (CONT'D)
Hey, I'm talking to you.

Noah sees, Cole doesn't respond, but looks uncomfortable

TRAVIS (CONT'D)
What, you only talk when your
boyfriend's around?

Cole still doesn't respond

Noah hesitates, but walks over to Travis and Cole

NOAH
Travis, what's your problem?

TRAVIS
No problem, Noah

NOAH
Good. Back off

TRAVIS
Whatever.

Travis walks off

TRAVIS (CONT'D)
(under his breath)
Not worth it anyway

Noah turns to Cole

NOAH
Hey, what's your name?

COLE
Cole

NOAH
I'm Noah...
(pause)
You don't have to just stand there
and let him talk to you like that

COLE
Thanks

Cole walks off still keeping his head down

NOAH
You should come to the game Friday.

Cole stops

He turns and looks up

COLE
Why?

NOAH
It'll be fun

COLE
Okay, maybe.

He starts walking again

Noah watches him leave

7 INT. NOAH'S KITCHEN - NIGHT

7

Julia, Noah, and DAVID are at the table eating lasagna

DAVID
Noah, Coach Reynolds called earlier
(pause)
He said you're already getting
attention from a lot of the big
football schools

NOAH
That's good

JULIA
Just good?

NOAH
It's great

JULIA
You seem... off. Are you okay?

NOAH
I'm just tired... from the move.

DAVID
Son, you know I tore my ACL in my
sophomore year of college

NOAH
Yeah, I know

DAVID
You still have this opportunity.
Don't waste it.

Noah nods slightly

NOAH
I won't

They finish eating and Noah takes his plate to the sink
He puts it in the sink and looks out the window
He goes up to his room

8 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

8

Noah lays in bed and looks at his phone
The time reads "8:29PM"

He waits a few seconds and it flips to "8:30PM"
 He looks to the window
 Through the gap, Ava's bedroom light flips on
 He looks for a few seconds before she closes the blinds
 He opens his phone and starts watching film
 He falls asleep after watching three plays
 The phone falls to his chest as he sleeps

9 EXT. FOOTBALL PRACTICE - MORNING 9

Noah walks onto the field sipping a protein shake and puts on his gear
 Coach Reynolds blows the whistle
 Everyone takes a lap and starts practice

10 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 10

Noah laying on his bed throwing a football to himself
 His alarm clock shows "8:29PM"
 Noah glances at the clock before it flips to "8:30PM"
 Noah glances at the window, and across the gap the light flips on
 Ava rolls her wheelchair to the window
 She holds up a paper to the window:
 "U just gonna stare every night?"
 Noah reaches over to his desk to get a notebook and pen
 He writes and holds up the notebook:
 "Depends. U contagious?"
 Ava reads it and gasps in mock offense
 She writes again and holds up:
 "Only emotionally"
 Noah glances at her oxygen tubes
 She writes again:

"You just move?"

Noah nods

She writes again and holds up:

"Welcome to the most boring street in America"

Noah writes back:

"It has potential"

There's a pause

He writes:

"I'm Noah btw"

Ava pauses and writes:

"I'm Ava"

He writes:

"Nice name. What kind of stuff do you like to do?"

Ava writes and holds up:

"I used to dance"

Noah pauses for a second

He writes:

"What kind?"

Ava writes:

"Ballet"

Noah stares at her for a second, down to her wheelchair, then back up

He writes:

"Like... Serious ballet?"

Ava rolls her eyes

Then writes:

"Yeah. serious ballet"

Noah laughs at her response then writes:

"Ok but were u good?"

Ava squints at him

She writes:

"Do a pirouette"

Noah puts his paper down and tries awkwardly, almost falling

She laughs and writes:
"I was better than you"

Noah sits back down

He writes back:
"I've never danced"

Ava writes:
"That's obvious"

Noah laughs at her response

Then he writes:
"So what happened?"

Ava looks down at her hands which are slightly trembling, and
adjusts the oxygen tubing

She writes:
"My lungs decided pliés were optional"

Noah doesn't smile, but nods

Then he writes:
"Do u miss it?"

Ava doesn't answer right away

Rain taps against the window

She holds up:
"I miss not thinking about breathing"

Noah writes back slowly:
"I just tripped over air"

Ava looks confused so Noah writes:
"So I think ur still winning"

Ava gives a genuine smile now

Her hands tremble slightly

She adjusts oxygen tubing

On her nightstand: medication bottles, hospital bracelet, and
a transplant list document

Her breathing is slightly labored

She looks out the window

Noah is still there in the other room, watching

11 INT. NOAH'S KITCHEN - MORNING

11

Julia is over the stove making breakfast

Noah comes down looking happier than he usually does

JULIA
Morning, Noah
(pause)
You look excited, is something
happening?

NOAH
Nothing's happening

JULIA
You sure?

NOAH
Yes, I'm sure. I was just...
talking to someone.

JULIA
Someone... A girl?

NOAH
Maybe

JULIA
What's her name?

NOAH
Ava

JULIA
That's nice

She walks from the stove with eggs and toast on a plate and
hands it to him

JULIA (CONT'D)
Eat. Then school.

Noah starts eating

12 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - MORNING

12

Ava's sitting alone on her bed

She looks out the window and sees Noah leaving for school

She transfers slowly to her wheelchair

Rolls across the room and tries to stand up
She falls back into her wheelchair quickly

AVA
This is so stupid

She looks at her old ballet shoes on the shelf
Picks one up and throws it across the room
Holds her face in her hands and starts crying quietly
Rolls over to where the shoe landed and picks it up
Rolls back to the shelf and puts it back
There's a soft knock on her door
Ava wipes her tears and speaks shakily

AVA (CONT'D)
Come in

Claire walks into the room and can immediately tell Ava's
been crying

She goes to Ava and hugs her

CLAIRE
What's wrong, Ava?

Ava clings to her, still in the wheelchair

AVA
I just feel so... Stuck
(pause)
I just want it to be over. I hate
this

CLAIRE
It'll be alright, honey. It'll get
better. I'm sure it'll be over soon

AVA
Promise?

CLAIRE
I want to

Claire pulls back slightly and puts both hands on Ava's face
Claire pulls Ava back into the hug, tighter now

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
You're strong. You'll get through
this

AVA
I want to believe that... But it's
hard to when I can't even stand on
my own

CLAIRE
I know, but it'll be okay

Ava glances at Noah's bedroom window to see his empty room

Claire notices her glance but pretends not to

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Ready to go downstairs and start
school?

AVA
I guess

Claire helps Ava out of her room and down the stairs

13 INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - AFTERNOON

13

Noah is standing with Mason by their lockers

MASON
You okay, man? You look... off

NOAH
I'm good. It's just... There's this
girl... She lives next door to me.

MASON
(teasingly)
Oh no. Emma's gonna be jealous
(pause)
Don't get too distracted.

NOAH
I won't

MASON
Okay bro, tell me about her. She
cute?

NOAH
Yeah. And funny, and sweet. She has
some kind of lung disease. But... I
think I kinda like her.

MASON
Like, like-like her?

NOAH
I mean, we only talked once... But
yeah

Noah and Mason don't notice Cole, listening from a distance

14 INT. AVA'S LIVING ROOM - AFTERNOON

14

Ava's doing school from her laptop

She looks distracted

CLAIRE
Ava, are you okay?

AVA
Yeah, I'm good

CLAIRE
What are you thinking about?

AVA
Something

CLAIRE
Something? Or Someone?

Ava's embarrassed now

AVA
Someone.

CLAIRE
Does this someone happen to be... a
boy?

AVA
Yeah

CLAIRE
Maybe... the boy next door?

AVA
How'd you know there's a boy next
door?

CLAIRE
Just a hunch
(pause)
(MORE)

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Plus I saw you look over at that
window earlier

Ava rolls her eyes playfully

AVA
Let me focus

She tries to focus back on her work

15 INT. SCHOOL CAFETERIA - AFTERNOON

15

Noah, Mason, Emma, NICK, and JESS are all eating and sitting
together

Travis and KENZIE are at another table with their friends

MASON
Did you all hear Noah's got a
girlfriend?

Emma tenses up

NOAH
She's not my girlfriend. And we
talked once!

MASON
Yeah, but you said you like her

Emma sits there quietly

Travis glances over from his table

NOAH
Can we talk about something else
now?

EMMA
Great idea! Let's talk about...
your football game this Friday?
(pause)
You know... something that actually
matters right now.

Noah glances at her, annoyed, but tries to hide it

Nobody else notices his glance

MASON
Yeah! Last time we played that team
we put BTA

JESS

I saw that game, it was good

NICK

Yeah, you guys did great on D,
didn't you get a pick that game?

MASON

Yeah, I did. It was great, man

The voices fade around Noah as his mind drifts back to Ava

16 INT. DANCE RECITAL STAGE - NIGHT (IMAGINED) 16

Noah sitting in the audience

Ava on stage in her ballet outfit dancing perfectly

Noah smiles

17 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 17

BEGIN MONTAGE

--Clock at 8:30 each night

--Papers pressed against windows

--Writing responses

--Mirroring each other's movements unintentionally

--Ava coughing, but acting okay

--Rainy nights, clear nights, windy nights

--Calendar sheets being torn, 4 months

END MONTAGE

Ava holds up a sign:
"Favorite movie?"

Noah writes something

18 INTERCUT - NOAH'S BEDROOM / AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 18

Noah holds up:
"Star Wars"

Ava gasps in mock offense, writes and shows:

"Wrong. LOTR is superior storytelling"

Noah holds up back:

"Hell no, star wars is way better"

Ava starts writing something

Ava holds up:

"What do you think of Harry Potter?"

Noah thinks for a second and then writes:

"Never seen it"

He holds it up

Ava's jaw drops then she writes aggressively and holds up:

"That's illegal"

Noah laughs

He writes:

"Then arrest me"

Ava writes back while laughing:

"I would if I could chase you"

Noah smiles and starts writing

Ava smiles

19 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

19

CLAIRE (O.S.)

Ava! Come here, baby!

Ava waves

Closes her blinds and wheels away from the window

Noah stops and rips out that page to write another note

Noah leaves the note on the window

20 INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - AFTERNOON

20

Noah's alone by his locker

Travis and Kenzie whispering across the hall

TRAVIS

Did you hear about Noah's new
"friend"?

KENZIE

You mean the sick girl?

Emma walks over and joins the conversation

EMMA

(whispering)

He's going to get his heart broken
over a girl who can't even leave
her room.

Emma turns to face Noah a bit and tucks a strand of hair
behind her ear

Noah tries to ignore their conversation, but it escalates

TRAVIS

And he shouldn't be wasting her
time either. She'll be dead soon
enough. She's not getting better.

Noah turns slightly, unable to hold back anymore

He walks over to Travis

NOAH

What did you just say?

TRAVIS

You heard me

NOAH

Say it again.

Emma touches Noah's arm

EMMA

Noah. Stop, it's not worth it

Noah shrugs her hand off of him

NOAH

(ignoring her)

Say it.

TRAVIS

I said why waste your time on her,
when she's already dying anyway?
She's not gonna get better.

NOAH

You don't talk about her like that.

TRAVIS

Or what?

Travis shoves Noah slightly

Noah shoves Travis against the locker

Hits him in the face

Blood trickles down Travis' nose

Some teachers rush over to break up the fight

21 INT. PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE - AFTERNOON

21

Noah and Travis both sit in the office across from PRINCIPAL WILLIAMS

PRINCIPAL WILLIAMS

Alright, Travis... Detention. Noah, you're suspended for a week.

(pause)

Travis. Back to class

Travis gets up and leaves

Noah stays behind a few seconds longer

PRINCIPAL WILLIAMS (CONT'D)

You want to explain yourself?

NOAH

I don't have an excuse. But he was talking shit about my friend.

PRINCIPAL WILLIAMS

What did he say?

NOAH

He called her "the sick girl", said "She'll be dead soon enough"

PRINCIPAL WILLIAMS

That doesn't justify starting a fight.

NOAH

I know.

PRINCIPAL WILLIAMS

Go home.

Noah gets up and leaves

22

INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - AFTERNOON

22

Emma's waiting outside the principal's office

Noah walks out, past Emma, ignoring her

Emma catches up to him, grabbing his shoulder

EMMA

What the hell was that?

NOAH

Nothing. Just leave it alone

EMMA

No, I'm not going to leave it alone, Noah. You're throwing everything away over a girl you just met!

NOAH

I'm not.

EMMA

Yeah, you kinda are.

NOAH

Emma. Drop it.

EMMA

Fine. But don't come crying to me when you lose your scholarship

Noah doesn't respond this time, he just walks away from Emma

23

EXT. STREET - AFTERNOON

23

Noah arrives at his house and Julia comes outside

JULIA

Noah? Why are you home already?

NOAH

I got suspended

JULIA

For what?

NOAH

I got into a fight

JULIA

You got into a fight?!

She immediately starts checking him for injuries

NOAH
Yeah, I'm fine

JULIA
What happened?

NOAH
I punched Travis

JULIA
Why?

NOAH
He was talking about Ava

JULIA
Ava? The girl next door?

She gestures toward Ava's house

NOAH
Yeah

JULIA
Was she there?

NOAH
No, she doesn't go to school

JULIA
What? Why not?

NOAH
She has a lung disease... She can't go out

JULIA
Oh... What did he say about her?

NOAH
They called her "The sick girl" and said "She'll be dead soon enough"

JULIA
You could've stood up for her without punching him.

NOAH
Whatever.

He goes inside

24 INT. NOAH'S KITCHEN - EVENING

24

Noah walks down from his room

David walks in

DAVID

Son, your mom told me what happened

NOAH

Okay

DAVID

Why would you start a fight over something so stupid? It's not worth getting suspended.

NOAH

I think it was

DAVID

You think it was worth it? You're being reckless. You're going to ruin your future. You have to control yourself

NOAH

I was controlling myself. I knew what I was doing.

DAVID

Then why the hell did you do it?

NOAH

You know what he said

DAVID

Yes, I know what he said. That's not more important than football. You have a serious future in football, son. You can't throw it away because of a stupid fight because you couldn't control yourself.

NOAH

I just told you. I made that choice. And to be completely honest, I don't regret it one bit.

DAVID

Go to your room.

Noah goes up to his room

25 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - EVENING

25

Noah's sitting on his bed scrolling on his phone
It rings with a call from Coach Reynolds
He waits a second before answering

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
I heard what happened

NOAH
Yeah

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
Why would you do that?

NOAH
He was being a dick and-

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
That's not a reason to punch him.
You have to think about the team
too. We needed you on Friday.
(pause)
After practice Monday, you owe me
50 up-downs, 40 pushups, 4 laps,
and suicides until I'm tired.

NOAH
Yes sir

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
Don't let it happen again.

NOAH
Yes sir

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
And watch the film.

Coach Reynolds hangs up

Noah puts his hand on the drawer of his nightstand and holds
it there for a second

He pulls it back and opens his phone to watch film

DISSOLVE TO:

26 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

26

Noah's laying in bed still watching film

He has a notebook with notes

NOAH
(to himself)
I didn't break down fast enough

The clock flips to "8:27PM"

His phone is on the nightstand

It starts ringing

Noah picks up the phone and it shows an unknown number

He hesitantly answers it, and puts the phone to his ear

AVA (V.O.)
You're actually proud of not
watching Harry Potter?!

Noah immediately smiles and goes to the window

Ava's at her window and waves

NOAH
You got my number from the sign.

AVA (V.O.)
You left it

NOAH
You stalking me now?

AVA (V.O.)
Please. I can't even walk to my
mailbox and back

He listens and can hear the strained breathing

NOAH
Okay. So sell me on it.

AVA (V.O.)
On what?

NOAH
Why should I watch it?

Ava thinks for a second

AVA (V.O.)
Well, magic is cool... And so is
having friends who'd fight a dark
lord for you.
(MORE)

AVA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 (pause)
 It's about people who stay

Noah smiles

Ava pauses for a few seconds

AVA
 Anyway... I saw you got home from
 school early today

NOAH
 Yeah

AVA (V.O.)
 Why?

NOAH
 I got suspended

AVA (V.O.)
 Why? What did you do?

NOAH
 Got into a fight.

She rolls her eyes playfully

AVA (V.O.)
 Noah.

27 INT. RESTAURANT - EVENING

27

Noah, Mason, Emma, Jess, and Nick are all eating dinner

EMMA
 You've been pretty quiet lately,
 you okay?

NOAH
 Just tired

EMMA
 You sure?

NOAH
 Yeah, I'm sure

EMMA
 Alright, eat your burger... You
 barely touched it

NOAH
I'm not hungry

Noah looks at his phone and sees the time: "8:15PM"

Noah stands up

EMMA
Where are you going?

NICK
You leaving already?

NOAH
Yeah, I gotta get home

JESS
Home? You usually stay out
until like 9

EMMA
(under her breath)
Of course you do.

NOAH
Yeah, I know. I can't tonight though

MASON
Alright then. See you tomorrow

Noah waves and leaves

28 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - EVENING

28

Noah walks into his bedroom and turns the light on right as
the clock hits "8:29PM"

He sits on his bed looking across the gap through the window,
it's getting dark outside

Ava's bedroom light flips on and she rolls into view, already
with her phone to her ear

Noah's phone starts ringing with Ava's name

He answers it quickly and sits at the window

AVA
Hi, Noah

NOAH
Hey

AVA
So you're like... out a lot, right?

NOAH
Yeah, why?

AVA
 Can you just, like... Tell me what
 it's like to be able to be outside
 nowadays?

He smiles slightly

Noah starts talking

DISSOLVE TO:

29

INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

29

Later that night, they're still on the phone

Her room is dim now, just the bedside lamp is on

She's in bed now, propped up by pillows with oxygen cannula
 on her cheeks

The phone is between her shoulder and ear

NOAH (V.O.)
 What is it?

AVA
 The disease?

NOAH (V.O.)
 Yeah.

AVA
 It's called Cystic Fibrosis. I was
 born with it, but it wasn't this
 bad until I was nine. That's when
 It got really bad and I stopped
 dancing... and actually having fun.

NOAH (V.O.)
 So you've been stuck inside for
 eight whole years?

AVA
 Pretty much

NOAH (V.O.)
 I'm sorry

There's a long silence

AVA
 You ever feel like you're stuck in
 the wrong body?

NOAH (V.O.)
Like... What do you mean?

Ava stares at the ceiling

AVA
Like your brain wants to run, or
scream, or do something stupid.
Sneak out, climb something, break
something. But your lungs are like
(pause)
"Nope"

She tries to laugh, but it turns to a cough

She mutes the phone

30

INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

30

Noah waits it out silently, sitting on the floor

Ava unmutes herself

AVA (V.O.)
Sorry.

NOAH
Don't apologize. You alright?

AVA (V.O.)
Yeah. I'm good

Noah stares at his cork board with college recruiting letters

NOAH
When I'm running routes, It feels
like that's the only time I'm not
thinking.

AVA (V.O.)
About what?

He hesitates and picks at a thread on his carpet

NOAH
Expectations.

AVA (V.O.)
(serious tone)
Must be hard... Being wanted.

NOAH
 (laughs slightly)
 Alright, now you're just trying to
 make me feel bad.

AVA (V.O.)
 No

31 INTERCUT - NOAH'S BEDROOM / AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT 31

She rolls onto her side to look at the rain on the window

AVA
 I just mean, People see you and
 they see potential.
 (pause)
 They look at me like I'm temporary

NOAH
 That's not-

AVA
 It's fine. I'm used to it. Doctors
 don't even talk to me, they talk
 around me, about me.

NOAH
 When recruiters call, they don't
 ask me what I want either. They
 just ask my forty time. My weight,
 vertical. Not if I'm tired, or
 scared

AVA
 Are you?

NOAH
 Yeah... sometimes

Ava coughs again

AVA
 Of what?

There's a long pause while Noah thinks

NOAH
 What if I peak at seventeen? What
 if this is the best I ever am? What
 if I'm only valuable when I'm fast?
 (pause)
 But that sounds childish and stupid
 compared to your issues

AVA
 It's not
 (pause)
 You know what I'm scared of?

NOAH
 What?

AVA
 I'm scared that if I get better, I
 won't know who I am without being
 "The sick girl"

Noah blinks, Not expecting that answer

NOAH
 You'd be... You.

Ava gives a tiny smile

AVA
 Easy for you to say. You've always
 had options.

NOAH
 You have options.

AVA
 Name one.

Noah opens his mouth, but doesn't speak

Rain starts falling harder against the window

NOAH
 Maybe your body's just slower than
 you

AVA
 That was dangerously poetic for a
 football player.

NOAH
 Don't tell anyone. I have a
 reputation to maintain.

She smiles

AVA
 Noah?

NOAH
 Yeah?

AVA
 If I ever get to run with you for
 real, Promise you won't slow down
 for me.

NOAH
 I wouldn't dare
 (pause)
 But I'll stay beside you

She closes her eyes and breathes slowly

AVA
 Okay.

Rain continues falling outside

32 EXT. FOOTBALL FIELD - NIGHT

32

It's Friday Night
 Stadium lights bright on the dark field, Crowd yelling
 Noah lines up at Wide Receiver
 Quarterback calls for the motion, then the snap
 Noah runs in silence except for his breathing
 The ball flies through the air to him
 He drops the pass

COACH REYNOLDS
 Noah! Lock the hell in!

He lines up again
 Quarterback calls for the motion, then snap again
 This time, he catches the pass
 The crowd erupts in cheers as he scores the touchdown

33 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

33

Ava's wrapped in a blanket on her bed streaming the game on
 her laptop
 She smiles and coughs but keeps smiling

34 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

34

Later that night

Noah is still sweaty from the game

Phone to his ear at the window

NOAH
You watched?

AVA (V.O.)
You allowed an interception in the
second quarter.

NOAH
You don't even know what an
interception is.

AVA (V.O.)
I Googled it, asshole.

Noah laughs softly

A second call comes in on Noah's phone, from a recruiter

NOAH
Hey, Ava. Give me a few minutes,
okay? A recruiter's calling.

AVA (V.O.)
Okay, I'll wait right here.

INTERCUT:

35 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

35

Ava looks over to the window and sees Noah on the phone
talking to the recruiter

After the short call her phone rings with Noah's name on the
screen, she answers

AVA
What'd they say?

NOAH (V.O.)
(excitedly)
I might be getting a full ride!

AVA
That's amazing!
(pause)
You deserve it.

NOAH (V.O.)
I don't know about that

AVA
What do you mean? You definitely
deserve it.
(pause)
And you have this opportunity, I
don't get a chance like that.
(firmly)
You better not waste it just
because you feel like you don't
deserve it.

NOAH (V.O.)
I know, I just feel... Stuck.
(pause)
When I'm running, I feel like I'm
not stuck.

AVA
I run in my head
(pause)
It's easier there

Long silence

DISSOLVE TO:

36

INT. NOAH'S BATHROOM - EVENING

36

Noah's phone is on the counter, the time reads "8:26PM"
He's staring blankly into the mirror, gripping the counter
Multiple missed calls and messages from recruiters
He glances at his forearm
Then at a partially open drawer
His phone buzzes

AVA (TEXT)
Noah

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
U busy?

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
Can u call?

Ava's name and picture shows up on the screen

Hesitates before answering

AVA (V.O.)
Noah, are you busy right now?

NOAH
No, why? What's up?

AVA (V.O.)
Then why didn't you answer my texts?

NOAH
You gave me like 5 seconds before you called

AVA (V.O.)
I guess that's fair
(pause)
Can you come to the window? I have something exciting to show you.

NOAH
Yeah, I'm coming.

Noah closes the drawer and walks out of the bathroom and to the window to look into Ava's room

Ava's sitting at her window

AVA (V.O.)
Okay, don't laugh.

NOAH
I won't.

Ava grips the window sill

Stands up, slowly, shaky

She falls back into her wheelchair, laughing slightly and coughing a bit

NOAH (CONT'D)
Holy Shit! That's amazing!

AVA (V.O.)
Thanks, Hopefully eventually I'll
be able to stand without help from
a window.

NOAH
Yeah

Noah sits down like he's ready to talk for the next few hours
Ava stays by her window

37 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - AFTERNOON 37

Ava's on the phone with Noah, who is at lunch at school

AVA
Noah

NOAH
Yeah?

AVA
Do you ever think about what
happens after?

NOAH
After what?

38 INTERCUT - AVA'S BEDROOM / SCHOOL CAFETERIA - AFTERNOON 38

AVA
After this
(pause)
I mean... you'll go to college,
probably forget that this house
even exists

NOAH
That's not-

She cuts him off

AVA
It's fine. That's what people do...
They move on

NOAH
What?

AVA
People move on. Or at least they
should.

NOAH
Ava... That's not what's going to
happen

AVA
Noah. It better be what happens

There's a long silence before someone speaks again

AVA (CONT'D)
Promise that you will

NOAH
I can't

AVA
Please Noah. I need you to...

NOAH
Ava. Don't-

AVA
Fine. But don't complain when your
life is miserable because you
couldn't just move on like everyone
else.

The bell rings for class

NOAH
I have to go to class

AVA
Okay, talk to you tonight?

NOAH
Yeah, tonight... Bye

AVA
Bye

Ava hangs up

Noah walks out of the cafeteria toward his class

Ava's laying in bed and the clock is at 6:30PM

Her phone starts buzzing

She checks it and sees Noah's name and photo on her screen

She answers it

AVA

Hey, it's early. Aren't you supposed to be at practice?

NOAH (V.O.)

Yeah... well, fuck practice, I wanted to talk to you instead, if you're not busy right now

She smiles

AVA

You're gonna be in so much trouble.

NOAH (V.O.)

Yeah, well it's whatever.

He looks out his window through hers

NOAH

You look bored.

AVA

I was, but not anymore. Just don't make it a habit of skipping practice just to talk to me

NOAH

No promises

40 EXT. FOOTBALL PRACTICE - MORNING

40

The sun is coming up

Noah trying to stay focused in the huddle

Runs the wrong route, the ball flies the opposite direction

Coach Reynolds pulls him aside

Noah pulls off his helmet and goes with him

COACH REYNOLDS

Noah. You okay? You're out of it today.

NOAH
Yeah, I'm alright.

COACH REYNOLDS
You can tell me if something's
bothering you, I want to know
what's got you so distracted so I
can fix it if it's something here.

NOAH
It's not something here.

COACH REYNOLDS
Then what is it?

NOAH
Just some personal stuff

COACH REYNOLDS
Alright, go back. And lock in.

Noah nods

Puts his helmet back on

Jogs back to the huddle

41 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - EVENING

41

Noah's sitting on his bed alone

Missed texts from Mason:

MASON (TEXT)
Where are you?

MASON (CONT'D)
You're seriously skipping practice
again?

He ignores the messages and calls Ava

AVA (V.O.)
Noah.
(pause)
You skipped practice again.

NOAH
Yeah, so?

AVA (V.O.)
So... you don't do that.

NOAH
I wanted to talk to you.

AVA (V.O.)
You could've called after.

NOAH
I didn't want to wait.

AVA (V.O.)
You don't have to keep doing that.

NOAH
Doing what?

AVA (V.O.)
Skipping things, like football
practice.
(pause)
Just to sit on the phone with me.

NOAH
I like talking to you.

AVA (V.O.)
Yeah... But why?

NOAH
What do you mean why?

AVA (V.O.)
I mean, is it actually because you
want to? Or because you feel like
you have to?

NOAH
Ava.

AVA (V.O.)
Because it kinda feels like you're
just here because I'm the "fragile
sick girl."

NOAH
That's not fair.
(pause)
I'm here because I want to be.

AVA (V.O.)
Then stop acting like I'm gonna
break every time I cough.

NOAH
I don't-

AVA (V.O.)
Yeah, you do.
(pause)
You go quiet, you choose your words
carefully, like I'm about to break.

Noah doesn't respond yet, processing everything

AVA
And then you skip practice
(pause)
Like I'm more important than the
rest of your life.

NOAH
Maybe you are.

AVA (V.O.)
No. I'm not.
(pause)
And I don't want to be.

NOAH
Why not?

AVA (V.O.)
Because, Noah, You're only here
because you feel guilty

NOAH
It's not guilt

AVA (V.O.)
Then what is it?

He doesn't have an answer yet

AVA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Yeah, that's what I thought.

NOAH
No, that's not-

AVA (V.O.)
Just stop. Stop talking to me just
because you feel like you have to.
Stop treating me like I'm this
fragile *thing* that's gonna break.
And stop skipping football practice

NOAH
Ava-

She hangs up

Noah puts his phone down
Stares at the ceiling

42 EXT. FOOTBALL PRACTICE - EVENING

42

Noah's practicing
He lines up
Runs a go route
Drops it
He lines up again
Runs it again
Catches it

43 INT. LOCKER ROOM - EVENING

43

Noah sits by his locker sweaty from practice
He pulls out his phone when the room clears out
He goes to his phone app
His finger hovers over Ava's contact
He closes the app and goes to messages instead
He opens a text with Ava and writes:
"I went to practice today"
He deletes it
Then he types:
"I'm sorry"
He hovers his thumb over send
But deletes it instead and locks his phone
He zones out again thinking

44 EXT. FOOTBALL FIELD - NIGHT (IMAGINED)

44

4 seconds on the clock, Noah lines up at Wide Receiver
He runs a fade route and catches the game-winning touchdown

Ava is jumping up and down and screaming from the bleachers
A bucket of Gatorade gets dumped on Coach Reynolds
Noah goes over to the side line, taking off his helmet
Ava comes down from the bleachers and runs to Noah
Noah drops his helmet as Ava jumps into his arms
She wraps her legs around his waist and he holds her there

45

INT. LOCKER ROOM - EVENING

45

Noah is zoned out
Mason walks over to him waving his hand in front of his face

MASON

Noah!

Noah snaps out of it and looks at Mason

MASON (CONT'D)

You good man?

NOAH

Yeah, I'm good. Just thinking.

MASON

Alright, lock in bro

46

INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

46

Noah's sitting on his bed
Clock flips from 8:29 to 8:30
Ava's bedroom light flips on and she glances at the window
Noah waves
She doesn't wave back, goes to her bed
He calls her

47

INTERCUT - NOAH'S BEDROOM / AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

47

She hesitates, but answers the call reluctantly

AVA (V.O.)
What do you want?

NOAH
To talk.

AVA (V.O.)
We talked yesterday.

NOAH
You hung up on me.

AVA (V.O.)
Because you weren't listening to
me!

NOAH
I was listening

AVA (V.O.)
No, you weren't. You were waiting
to say something that would fix it.
(pause)
You don't have to fix me, Noah.

NOAH
I know that.

AVA (V.O.)
Then act like it.

Noah looks toward her window and she's not there

NOAH
Can you at least come to the
window?

She slowly rolls to the window

AVA
Fine, I'm here. Happy?

NOAH
Yes... Look Ava, I didn't skip
practice because I feel bad for you

Ava crosses her arms

AVA
Then why did you?

NOAH
Because when I'm at practice it's
not like I'm focused anyway.
(MORE)

NOAH (CONT'D)

(pause)

So what's the difference if I'm
here instead of there?

Ava's expression softens slightly

AVA

The difference is, that's your
life.

NOAH

It's part of it

AVA

Yeah. A really big part of it.

(pause)

Noah. I don't want to be the reason
you lose that.

NOAH

You're not making me lose anything.

(pause)

I'm not losing anything

AVA

You are if you keep choosing me
over football

NOAH

I'm not

AVA

Yes you are.

NOAH

So what do you want? For me to just
stop talking to you?

AVA

No, But you shouldn't be shuffling
your life around like this. Not for
someone who might not even...

She trails off

NOAH

Might not what?

AVA

Nothing

NOAH

No, say it.

AVA

This is exactly what I mean, Noah.
You keep pushing until it turns
into something serious like this.

NOAH

It is serious, Ava.

AVA

It doesn't have to be. Not all the
time.

(pause)

Sometimes I just want to talk about
it like it doesn't matter.

NOAH

It does matter

AVA

Why?

NOAH

It matters because you matter

AVA

Don't say that.

NOAH

Why not?

She sighs

AVA

Never mind. Just go to practice
tomorrow.

NOAH

Okay

(pause)

Goodnight, Ava.

She hesitates before responding

AVA

Goodnight.

She hangs up and rolls away from the window

Her clock's hour hand goes around twice

Ava laying on her bed with her phone

She glances at the window, the blinds are closed
 She opens her phone app and hovers over Noah's name
 She locks her phone and sets it down beside her

AVA
 (whispering to herself)
 You're so stupid

She lays there for a bit before shifting to her wheelchair
 She rolls over to the window and opens her blinds
 She looks into Noah's room
 It's dark

She writes:
 "I'm sorry"

She holds it up, then puts it back down and rips it up
 She hovers her pen over the notebook, but doesn't write again
 A few seconds later the light in Noah's room flips on
 Ava straightens up immediately
 Noah sees her, barely acknowledges her
 She looks down and scribbles quickly on the notebook:
 "did u go to practice?"

49 INTERCUT - AVA'S BEDROOM / NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

49

Noah walks to the window and writes back:
 "yeah"

Ava exhales, relieved

She writes:
 "Good"

He doesn't respond yet

Ava writes again:
 "I'm sorry"

Noah writes:
 "Can u call?"

She nods, gets her phone and calls him quickly

AVA
I'm sorry, Noah

NOAH
For which part?

AVA
All of it.

NOAH
I'm sorry too, you weren't wrong...
About some of it.

AVA
I was being a bitch about it

NOAH
It's fine, Ava.

AVA
It's not.
(pause)
I just... don't want to be a
problem for you.

NOAH
You're not a problem

AVA
So you're going to practice
tomorrow too?

NOAH
Okay. Fine, I'll go to practice,
but as soon as I'm back, we'll
call?

AVA
Deal.

NOAH
Ava, you know that I actually like
talking to you, and that it's not
because I "feel bad", right?

AVA
Yeah, I know. It's just... like I
said before... I didn't want to be
a problem

NOAH
You never have been, and you never
will be.

AVA
Promise?

NOAH
I promise

AVA
Thank you, Noah. I really needed to
hear that... Goodnight.

NOAH
Goodnight.

Noah goes to bed now and Ava does the same
Ava lays back in bed, looking happier
Her clock's hour hand goes around twice

50 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

50

Another night
Her lights are dim, she seems more tired tonight
She plugs in her phone which shows it's dead
She goes to the window with a sign
She writes and holds up:
"My phone died"
Noah writes, then holds up:
"Ok"
Ava writes:
"Do you think God plans everything?"
Noah writes back:
"I used to"
Ava thinks, then writes:
"What changed?"
He hesitates, then writes:
"I prayed for something important once. didn't happen"
Ava writes back:
"What was it?"
Noah writes again:
"My grandma had cancer. She died"

Ava takes her time writing the next one:
"I don't think he plans it all"

Noah looks confused through the window

Ava holds up the next page:
"I just think he doesn't waste anything"

He looks at her and thinks for a couple seconds

The wind outside picks up and it starts raining

Ava checks her phone and it's lit up

Her lock screen shows 9:18PM

She calls Noah

AVA
My dad left when I was twelve.

NOAH (V.O.)
I'm sorry

AVA
He left because he "got tired"

NOAH (V.O.)
You miss him?

AVA
I miss who he was before he got
tired of me, not the piece of shit
he is now.
(pause)
That's why I told you I like
stories where people stay

Long silence

NOAH (V.O.)
Yeah. I like those stories too

AVA
I don't think God would've planned
for him to leave. But I don't think
he's wasting this situation either.

NOAH (V.O.)
Yeah

Another long pause

AVA
You know, I thought you would've
left by now too. It's already been
like 4 months and you're still
here.

NOAH (V.O.)
I told you, I'm not leaving.

51 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - MORNING 51

Noah quietly getting ready for school
He glances over at Ava's bedroom window
Her room is dark, rain is pouring outside
Noah reaches for his backpack
Walks out of his room

52 EXT. STREET - MORNING 52

Noah comes out of his house
Starts walking to his car
He sees Ava outside in the rain in her wheelchair

NOAH
Ava?

Ava turns her head and sees Noah

AVA
Oh, hi.

NOAH
What are you doing out here?

AVA
I couldn't stay inside anymore, it
was killing me

NOAH
Yeah, well this is too. Maybe you
should go back inside

He starts to walk over to her

Ava sighs and looks up, rain hitting her face, thinking

AVA
Five more minutes?

NOAH
No, Ava

She looks down, then up to Noah

AVA
Fine. I guess you're right. Help me?

NOAH
Yeah

Noah pushes her wheelchair to her front door

He opens the door

Pushes her inside

The door closes behind them

53 EXT. OUTSIDE SCHOOL - AFTERNOON

53

After school, the lot is mostly empty

Noah stands by his car

Mason, Emma, Jess, and Nick all walk out in a group, laughing and talking

NICK
Yo Noah! You coming to hang out later?

Noah hesitates

NOAH
Yeah

Emma notices the hesitation, but doesn't comment on it

EMMA
Okay, see you then!

Noah gets in his car and leaves

Emma turns to the others

EMMA (CONT'D)
He hesitated.

MASON

So?

EMMA

So, why did he hesitate?

JESS

Probably just thinking to make sure
he didn't have anything else
planned?

EMMA

He's always hesitating now. Ever
since he met that girl next door to
him.

NICK

Aw, is somebody jealous?

EMMA

No. I'm not jealous. Just...
worried.

JESS

What is there to be worried about?

EMMA

His future, he literally hit Travis
and got suspended over her. She
can't be that important.

MASON

She can be to him.

They all keep walking and split off from each other

EMMA

(under her breath)
She shouldn't be.

54

INT. RESTAURANT - EVENING

54

Everyone's there but Noah

Emma looks around nervously

EMMA

Where is he?

NICK

Chill, he said he'll be here

Noah walks in and sits down

MASON
Hey Noah

NOAH
Hi

JESS
(whispering to Emma)
I told you

Emma elbows Jess under the table

EMMA
You're late.

NOAH
Yeah, I know

EMMA
You said you'd be here

NOAH
I am here

EMMA
Now you are... where were you?

NOAH
Out

NICK
Out where?

NOAH
Why does it matter?

EMMA
Because you've been acting weird

NOAH
I'm not acting weird

EMMA
You hesitated earlier when we asked
if you'd be here

NOAH
That doesn't mean anything

EMMA
It does when it's every time now

JESS
Guys-

EMMA

Seriously, Noah. Ever since you met her, it's like nothing else matters to you anymore

NOAH

That's not true

EMMA

Then why? What's wrong?

(pause)

Because from my point of view, it looks like you're just throwing everything away

NICK

She kinda has a point

NOAH

No. She doesn't

MASON

You literally got suspended

NOAH

I know

MASON

Over her

EMMA

She can't be that important, Noah.

NOAH

You don't know anything about her.

EMMA

Then tell us

NOAH

It's not your business

EMMA

It is when it's affecting us too

JESS

Emma-

EMMA

What? I'm just trying to understand

NOAH

No you aren't.

EMMA

Then help me understand. What makes
her worth all this

Noah's breathing shifts, he loses his composure

NOAH

You think she wanted this?

EMMA

Wanted what?

NOAH

The disease, to be stuck inside,
for her dad to leave just cause he
'got tired'

The others all look up, wide eyed

Noah immediately regrets letting it slip out

EMMA

What?

NOAH

(under his breath)
Shit

MASON

Her dad left?

NOAH

It's not- that's not-
(pause)
It's not your business

EMMA

You never mentioned that before

NOAH

Like I said. It's not your business

Everyone's quiet now

EMMA

Noah

NOAH

Drop it.

Noah stands up abruptly

NICK

Bro, you just got here

NOAH
Yeah, and now I'm leaving.

He turns to walk out

JESS
Wait-

She gets cut off by the door closing behind Noah

55 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

55

Thunder outside, wind and rain hitting the windows

Ava's phone is plugged in on her nightstand, so they're doing the signs again

Ava laughs at something Noah writes, but it turns to coughing

She looks down

There's a kink in the oxygen tube where it's caught on the arm of her wheelchair

She adjusts it, then the airflow returns to normal

NOAH
(mouthing)
You okay?

Ava nods quickly

She holds up a sign:
"When I get out, we're marathoning Harry Potter outside"

Noah writes:
"Deal"

Ava writes back:
"No complaining"

Noah writes back:
"No promises"

She laughs again, this turns into a cough, worse than normal

INTERCUT:

56 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

56

While she's coughing he looks away to write a note
"I think I'm falling for U"

But he doesn't hold it up yet

NOAH
You sure you're good?

He puts a thumbs up questioningly

Ava nods again, but she's still coughing

NOAH (CONT'D)
Ava?

She tries to answer, but can't

She starts coughing harder and falls out of frame

Noah freezes for half a second, dropping the note

NOAH (CONT'D)
Ava?!
(short pause)
Shit.

Thunder crashes outside

He runs down the stairs

57

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

57

Noah throws his front door open

His driveway is empty

Noah runs to her front door and starts knocking loudly

Claire opens the door and sees Noah soaked at her door

CLAIRE
Noah?

NOAH
It's Ava... She collapsed in her
room

Claire and Noah run up to Ava's room

Claire calls 911 in the background

Noah kneels beside Ava

Sirens sound in the distance

A couple minutes later EMTs rush in

Noah steps back from Ava to let the EMTs work

58 INT. CAR ON THE WAY TO HOSPITAL - NIGHT

58

Claire is driving fast

Noah's in the passenger seat

Noah looks out the window at the rain

59 INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM - NIGHT

59

Noah is sitting there alone, soaked

He overhears a doctor speaking

DOCTOR SMITH

She's gone

Noah assumes they're talking about Ava

His breath catches in his throat

Tears form in his eyes as he sits there for a few seconds

Another doctor walks into the room

DOCTOR HIGGINS

You're here for Ava Bennett?

NOAH

Yes

DOCTOR HIGGINS

She's stable. We're still waiting
on a diagnosis. Her mother is in
the room with her now.

Doctor Higgins points to a hall

Noah calms slightly at this news

NOAH

Thank you

He gets up and walks into the hall

60 INT. HOSPITAL ICU - NIGHT

60

Machines humming

Ava lies in bed unconscious, her chest moving mechanically

Noah stands in the doorway still soaked

Claire sits beside Ava's bed holding her hand

DOCTOR SMITH
(quietly to Claire)
She's in severe respiratory
failure. Her lungs are barely
functioning

Noah listens without meaning to

DOCTOR SMITH (CONT'D)
She needs a bilateral lung
transplant

Claire nods like she understands

DOCTOR SMITH (CONT'D)
The waitlist for her blood type is
long. Without that transplant we're
talking a week at most.

Claire breaks down crying, still holding Ava's hand

Noah's stares at the ventilator, blinking hard

He walks out of the room into the hall

61 INT. HOSPITAL STAIRWELL - NIGHT

61

Heavy metal door slams shut as Noah enters

He runs his hand through his wet hair

He hits the metal railing, which causes his hand to bleed
slightly and causes a loud echo of the metal, he doesn't care

He grips the railing

NOAH
Don't do this. Don't take her.

He leans against the wall and slides down, hyperventilating

NOAH (CONT'D)
Why would you do this? Why would
you let her hurt like this?

He tries to control his breathing slowly and closes his eyes

One tear slips out

Clasps his hands together

NOAH (CONT'D)

God, I don't know if you're
listening or if you're even real...
But if you are, please don't take
her... I'll do anything, God... I
need her to be okay. I can't lose
her.

He stands up and slowly goes out of the stairwell

62

INT. HOSPITAL HALLWAY - NIGHT

62

Noah stands alone against the wall

He's watching film on his phone, barely paying attention

It rings and shows Coach Reynolds Caller ID

He hesitates, but answers

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)

Where were you today? A storm
doesn't mean practice is cancelled.
We have indoor facilities for a
reason.

NOAH

I know, I didn't skip cause of the
storm. I'm at the hospital.

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)

Oh, I didn't know that... Are you
okay?

NOAH

Yeah, I'm good. I'm not here for me

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)

Family?

NOAH

A friend

(pause)

She has a lung disease, and...
she's not doing well right now

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
I'm sorry to hear that... I do have
some news that might make you feel
a bit better though.

NOAH
What is it?

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
I just got off the phone with a
recruiter
(pause)
He's coming Friday. In person. To
see you play
(pause)
You play like you did last week,
and that offer you got is almost
guaranteed.

Noah looks toward Ava's ICU room

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.) (CONT'D)
This is everything you've worked
for, kid.

NOAH
I know

COACH REYNOLDS (V.O.)
Show up to practice tomorrow.

Coach Reynolds hangs up

Noah puts his phone away and turns slightly

He hears two doctors speaking quietly around the corner

DOCTOR SMITH (O.S.)
If we had two living donors, we
could attempt a lobar transplant.

Noah turns slightly more to hear them

DOCTOR HIGGINS (O.S.)
It's rare. Major surgery. Both
donors lose about twenty to thirty
percent permanent lung capacity

Noah doesn't move

DOCTOR SMITH (O.S.)
But it's faster than waiting for
cadaver lungs.

Noah glances into the window and sees Ava laying there, then back to his phone

He glances into the ICU window

Claire next to her holding her hand

As he sees her laying there the monitor spikes once, then returns to normal

He locks his phone and puts it in his pocket

He takes a deep breath in and goes around the corner

He goes up to the doctors

NOAH

How do I get tested?

Doctor Smith and Doctor Higgins look at him confused

DOCTOR SMITH

What?

NOAH

For the lung donation transplant,
For Ava.

DOCTOR HIGGINS

Are you her family?

NOAH

No

(pause)

But can't we test anyway?

The doctors exchange a look

DOCTOR HIGGINS

Don't you play football?

NOAH

Yeah, so?

DOCTOR SMITH

Kid, if you were a match. You
wouldn't play football ever again.

NOAH

I know.

DOCTOR HIGGINS
 You're still a minor. You'd need
 parental consent even to get tested
 for compatibility.

NOAH
 Okay

Noah nods and walks away to call his parents

JULIA (V.O.)
 Hi, Noah. We're almost home.

NOAH
 That's not why I called... I'm at
 the hospital, can you and Dad come?

JULIA (V.O.)
 (panicked)
 What? Why? Are you hurt?

NOAH
 No. I'm fine.

JULIA (V.O.)
 Then what's going on?

Noah glances back to the ICU doors, then back to the phone

NOAH
 I just need you both to come. Now.

JULIA (V.O.)
 We're on the way.

Noah hangs up, then just looks back into the ICU

63 INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM - NIGHT

63

Mostly empty, Noah sits in a chair, his head in his hands
 Julia and David rush in

JULIA
 Are you okay?

She grabs his face, checking him

DAVID
 What happened? Did you get into a
 fight again? Are you okay?

NOAH
No. I'm fine.

His parents look confused

DAVID
Then why are we here?

Noah takes a breath

NOAH
There's a girl.

JULIA
A girl... Ava?

NOAH
Yeah. She's in the ICU

Julia and David's confusion turns to concern

DAVID
Okay? This is the girl you've been
talking to?

NOAH
Yes. She needs a lung transplant

JULIA
And?

Noah looks them both in the eyes

NOAH
They can do a living Lobar
Transplant.
(pause)
She'd need two donors.

DAVID
(sternly)
No.

NOAH
They can test me

JULIA
Noah.

NOAH
She has days

DAVID

And that is tragic. But it's not
your responsibility.

NOAH

Then whose is it?!

The few people in the waiting room turn heads at the yell

DAVID

You barely even know this girl!

NOAH

I know her well enough!

(pause)

I know she hates when people pity
her. I know she pretends her lungs
don't hurt when they do. I know she
runs in her head because she can't
in real life.

JULIA

You've known her for what, a few
months?

NOAH

4... Long enough!

DAVID

Long enough to throw away your
future?!

NOAH

It's not throwing it away!

DAVID

You will never play football again!

NOAH

I know!

JULIA

You worked your whole life for
this. Every camp, every practice,
every injury

NOAH

Exactly, and what's the point of it
if I'm not doing something that
actually matters!

DAVID

Football Matters!

NOAH
Not more than her life!

His father steps closer now

DAVID
You are seventeen. You do not get
to make a permanent decision like
this over a girl you just met.

Noah unconsciously glances down at his forearm

He steps forward, so they're eye to eye

NOAH
I already did.

JULIA
Noah. Honey... You're scared,
you're reacting.

NOAH
I'm not scared

He looks down, then back up

NOAH (CONT'D)
Before her, nothing felt real.
(pause)
So no, I'm not just reacting. This
is the first thing I've been really
sure about in a long time. And I
can't lose her... I love her.

DAVID
You love her?

NOAH
Yes.

DAVID
Enough to quit football entirely

NOAH
Yes! Enough to quit anything.
Everything.

JULIA
What if something happens to you?

NOAH
Then something happens. I don't
care.

Tears start to well up in Julia's eyes

DAVID
You're our son.

NOAH
And she's someone's daughter!
(long pause)
You taught me to be strong, to show
up, to not walk away. So don't ask
me to walk away now.

DAVID
You don't understand what you're
giving up

NOAH
I do. I understand perfectly.
(pause)
They said I won't play again.

JULIA
And you still want to do this?

NOAH
Yes.

DAVID
Why?

NOAH
Because I told her I wasn't
leaving.

Silence for several seconds

DAVID
If we sign this, your life changes.

NOAH
It already did. The second I met
her

Julia grips Noah's hand tightly and her tears fall freely

David finally looks at Noah again

Noah doesn't move

Julia looks at him like she's already imagining the scar

David gently places his hand on Julia's shoulder

DAVID
We need the paperwork.

Doctor Smith approaches with the papers and a pen
David and Julia sign the papers
Noah watches them sign everything
Finally, Julia steps forward and hugs Noah carefully
She rests her head on his shoulder for just a second

JULIA
(whispering)
Come back to me

Noah wraps his arms around her firmly
Over Julia's shoulder Noah and David lock eyes
David Nods slightly

64 INT. AVA'S ICU ROOM - NIGHT

64

Noah sits beside Ava's bed holding her hand
In the other hand he's holding a worn copy of Harry Potter
and the Sorcerer's Stone
He reads quietly
He looks at her

NOAH
You still owe me an explanation
about this whole Horcrux thing.

The machines continue breathing for her
He sets the book down and adjusts a strand of hair from her
face while being careful not to disturb the tubes

65 EXT. OUTSIDE HOSPITAL - NIGHT

65

Not raining, but still cloudy, dark, and windy
Noah stands alone, looking up at the sky

NOAH
 I don't know if you're listening.
 (pause)
 But I'm here

He struggles to find the words to say

NOAH (CONT'D)
 Take whatever you want from me,
 just don't take her. Please...

The wind blows and he stands there longer than he needs to

66 INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM - MORNING

66

Noah sits in a chair quietly leaning forward

His phone buzzes, but he ignores it

It buzzes again

He checks it to find two texts from Mason

MASON (TEXT)
 Noah

MASON (TEXT) (CONT'D)
 Why aren't u at film study?

Noah types back

NOAH (TEXT)
 Busy

Typing bubbles show up

MASON (TEXT)
 You never miss film studies

NOAH (TEXT)
 It's important. Can't make it today

Noah locks his phone and puts it away

67 INT. HOSPITAL FAMILY CONSULT ROOM - MORNING

67

Soft morning light filters in through half-closed blinds

Noah sits with Claire

Claire is holding a cup of untouched coffee

DOCTOR HIGGINS

We can begin compatibility testing
for living donors immediately. But
she would need two compatible donors
for a lobar transplant, and the
chances of that are slim to none.

Claire looks at Noah for the first time since that night

Noah looks back at her

NOAH

I'm getting tested

Claire looks at him alarmed now

CLAIRE

No.

NOAH

It's just testing

CLAIRE

You're a child

NOAH

I'm seventeen

CLAIRE

Exactly

Noah's parents stay quiet

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

You think I could live with myself
if something happened to you?

NOAH

You think I could live with myself
if I didn't at least try to help
her?

CLAIRE

She wouldn't want this

NOAH

She wouldn't want to die either

Claire closes her eyes briefly

CLAIRE

You barely know her

NOAH
I know enough

Claire just stares into space

BEGIN MONTAGE

--Church bulletin board with a typed notice: "Urgent donor testing needed"

--A few teenagers at school whispering about it

--A man in his 30s rolling up his sleeve for bloodwork

--A middle-aged woman shaking her head gently as a nurse explains she isn't compatible

--Cole seeing Noah's post

--Another potential donor leaving the office disappointed

CLAIRE
People are trying, baby

END MONTAGE

68 INT. HOSPITAL HALLWAY - AFTERNOON

68

Doctor Higgins approaches Claire and Noah

DOCTOR HIGGINS
We had several volunteers tested
(pause)
Two were incompatible. One had
underlying health issues that
disqualify him.

Claire's face falls slightly

Noah nods

DOCTOR HIGGINS (CONT'D)
We're still waiting on a few more
results. And, Noah. We're ready to
test you and one more person

69 INT. HOSPITAL BLOOD DRAW ROOM - EVENING

69

Noah sits across from Cole

They both get blood drawn

70

INT. HOSPITAL FAMILY CONSULT ROOM - EVENING

70

Doctor Smith enters with a folder

DOCTOR SMITH

Noah is a match

(pause)

We also have a second compatible donor

CLAIRE

Who?

Cole walks in, already uncomfortable with the attention

He keeps his hands in his hoodie pockets

COLE

Hey

Claire slowly stands

CLAIRE

You don't even know her.

Cole shrugs

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

Why would you do this

COLE

Because I can.

(pause)

And I know what it's like to wait.

(pause)

My-

He pauses, choosing his words carefully

COLE (CONT'D)

Friend... died waiting for a transplant.

Noah looks over at him

Cole looks to Claire again

COLE (CONT'D)

She doesn't owe me anything. I don't want visits. Or attention... Just let it help

CLAIRE

Thank you.

He nods once awkwardly

COLE

Yeah

He turns to Noah

COLE (CONT'D)

I guess we're doing this.

Noah nods

DOCTOR SMITH

I'll be honest. Finding two viable donors in this time frame is very rare.

Claire closes her eyes and tilts her head up

CLAIRE

(whispering)

Thank you

Cole leaves the room but turns back once

COLE

Just let me know when.

Then he leaves

71 INT. HOSPITAL PRE-OP AREA - EARLY MORNING

71

Dim morning light through the windows

Three separate rooms, Noah in one, Cole in another, Ava in the other

Julia and David are with Noah

A nurse wheels Noah to the OR, in the hall he sees Ava through the glass of her room

He reaches his hand slightly toward the glass as he passes

BEGIN MONTAGE

--Surgeons scrubbing in

--Ava being prepped

--Noah staring at the ceiling lights

--Cole staring at the same lights in another room

--Claire clutching a cross necklace in the waiting room

--Julia gripping David's hand tightly

NURSE 1
Count back from ten

NOAH
Ten, Nine, Eight

COLE
Seven, Six, Five

END MONTAGE

72 INT. OPERATING ROOM - AFTERNOON

72

Monitors beeping steadily, surgeons working

Ava's monitor shifts and the beeping changes

NURSE 1
We're losing sinus rhythm

SURGEON
Push epi, Increase oxygen

Her heart rate spikes dangerously for five seconds

Flatline

NURSE 2
We're losing her

INTERCUT:

73 INT. DANCE RECITAL STAGE - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

73

Eight year old Ava stands center stage in a pale pink tutu

Her hair is pulled into a tight bun, ballet slippers soft
against the polished wood

Delicate piano music is playing through the theater

She dances happily

In the audience is her father, MICHAEL

INTERCUT:

74 INT. OPERATING ROOM - AFTERNOON

74

SURGEON
Start compressions. Now.

A nurse begins chest compressions

NURSE 1
Charging to 200

Defibrillator paddles press to her chest

SURGEON
Clear!

The flatline continues after the shock

INTERCUT:

75 INT. DANCE STUDIO - MORNING (FLASHBACK)

75

Sunlight through tall windows

Little Ava stands in front of a mirror practicing her dances

Claire watching

She spins and stumbles

AVA
Shit

CLAIRE
Language, Ava

AVA
Sorry, Mommy. I keep falling

CLAIRE
It's okay, baby. Try again.

She tries again and lands it perfectly with a smile

INTERCUT:

76 INT. OPERATING ROOM - AFTERNOON

76

The flatline continues

Compressions Continue

NURSE 2
No response

SURGEON
Again. Charge.

The defibrillator charges up

NURSE 1
Ready

SURGEON
Clear!

They shock her and her body jolts, but the flatline continues

INTERCUT:

77 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

77

Rain tapping against glass

Noah holds up a paper to the window
"Still here"

Ava writes and holds up her own paper
"Obviously"

Noah writes another page
"You ever get tired of me?"

Ava pretends to think about it, then writes
"Not yet"

Noah thinks for a couple seconds, then writes
"Good. cuz I'm not leaving"

Ava lowers her paper, and nods slowly

Rain keeps falling outside

INTERCUT:

78 INT. OPERATING ROOM - AFTERNOON

78

SURGEON
Clear!

They shock her again, this time the tone breaks

One beep

Then another

NURSE 2
We've got a pulse.

Short pause

SURGEON
Okay, Let's continue

They continue the surgery

79 INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM - EVENING

79

Claire, David, Julia, and Cole's parents are all sitting together staring into space waiting

Surgeon enters the room

Everyone stands

SURGEON
The procedures were successful.
They're all stable.

Julia hugs David, and Cole's parents hug

Claire sits down again

80 INT. RECOVERY ROOM - EVENING

80

Cole wakes first

COLE
How'd it go?

NURSE 1
Everything went well. Do you want to stay and wait for her to wake up?

COLE
No. I want to get out of here before either of them wake up if possible.

NURSE 1
Okay

The nurse helps Cole up and out of the room carefully

He exits the room and inhales deeply

He looks back once, then leaves
 After a few more minutes, Noah wakes up
 He winces slightly as he tries to sit up
 The nurse notices

NURSE 1 (CONT'D)
 Easy there buddy. Surgery went
 well.

Noah looks over to Ava

NOAH
 Her?

NURSE 1
 Still Sedated, but stable.

Noah feels the limitation of his breathing now

DISSOLVE TO:

81 INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - AFTERNOON

81

SUPER: "3 DAYS LATER"

Ava lies in bed asleep, but without a ventilator now, just a
 nasal cannula

Noah's sitting in the chair next to her bed, breathing slowly
 while reading again

NOAH
 You're missing the good part, Ava.

He keeps reading

DISSOLVE TO:

82 INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - MORNING

82

Soft morning light, monitors humming low, Ava still asleep

Claire and Noah are both there

Claire's asleep, Noah's in a chair looking out the window

Ava starts to wake up

Claire hears Ava and jolts awake

Noah looks over to Ava

CLAIRE
Ava?

AVA
W- What... Happened?

Claire immediately grabs her hand

CLAIRE
You're okay. You're okay!

Ava frowns as she remembers the night when she passed out

She looks at Noah, who is now looking at her

AVA
You're here.

NOAH
I told you I'm not leaving

She puts her hand on her chest

Ava takes another deep breath

AVA
Why doesn't it... hurt?

Ava moves her legs slightly, testing her body

AVA (CONT'D)
I can... I can breathe

Ava looks at Noah's face

AVA (CONT'D)
You look... tired.

Ava's eyes drop to his chest and she notices the scar where
it's slightly visible above his shirt

Her eyes widen

AVA (CONT'D)
What happened to you?

NOAH
You needed new lungs.

AVA

No.

(pause)

No... That's not- No

Claire squeezes Ava's hand

CLAIRE

Baby

AVA

No.

She looks closer at the surgical marks by his collarbone

Then back to his face

AVA (CONT'D)

You didn't.

NOAH

You needed two donors.

AVA

You... You can't play though

Ava starts breathing faster now

AVA (CONT'D)

Why would you do that?! I didn't
ask you to do that!

Tears start to spill down her face

She tries to push herself up, and she winces hard

NOAH

Hey... Hey, Careful.

He moves closer while speaking

She cuts him off

AVA

You had everything! You were
supposed to leave! You were
supposed to go somewhere!

NOAH

I told you I wasn't leaving, Ava.

Tears spill down Ava's face

AVA
You can't play now! You can't play
in the championship! You can't play
in college!

NOAH
I know

AVA
You don't get to decide that!

NOAH
Yeah. I do.

AVA
I don't want to be the reason you
give up on your dream! You promised
you wouldn't slow down for me!

NOAH
I'm not slowing down. Just...
changing direction.

Ava stares at him through her tears

AVA
What if something happens to you?!
What if one day you wake up and
can't breathe either?!

NOAH
Then it happens. But I'll be happy
knowing you get to breathe.

Ava takes a deep breath, trying to calm herself

AVA
It's quiet. It's never quiet.

Claire also starts crying now

Ava looks at Noah, her expression softens

AVA (CONT'D)
Was it worth it?

Noah watches Ava take another full breath

NOAH
Yeah

He finally reaches out and holds her hand

She squeezes back, not letting go

He leans toward the bed and hugs her gently

DISSOLVE TO:

83

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - EVENING

83

Ava's in her bed

Noah's in the corner in the chair

Claire is sitting there too

A Nurse is there

CLAIRE

I'm going to get some food

NOAH

Okay

Okay

AVA

Claire walks out of the room

Ava sits up

AVA (CONT'D)

Can you help me get up, please?

NURSE 1

Yes, careful though

Nurse 1 helps Ava swing her legs off the bed

Ava takes a deep breath

AVA

You can let go

NURSE 1

Are you sure?

AVA

Yes, let go.

Ava tries to stand

She collapses back onto the bed, frustrated

She lays there staring at the ceiling

AVA (CONT'D)

Why can't I do this?

NURSE 1
Your body's relearning everything

AVA
I used to dance
(pause)
Then I couldn't stand at all
(pause)
Now I'm "better" and I still can't
even stand

NURSE 1
It'll take time

AVA
(to herself now)
This is stupid... I can breathe...
Why can't I do anything else?

Noah looks over not knowing if he should try to help

He takes a step toward Ava

She snaps

AVA (CONT'D)
Sit down.

Noah sits back down

AVA (CONT'D)
I don't need help with everything!

There's a long silence

AVA (CONT'D)
Sorry

NOAH
It's alright

DISSOLVE TO:

84 INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - NIGHT

84

The room is dim, Ava's in her bed, staring at the ceiling

AVA
(to herself)
Why can't I stand?

She turns to the window and looks outside

She takes a full deep breath

She closes her eyes

85 INT. HOSPITAL REHAB HALLWAY - AFTERNOON

85

Ava walking slowly with a nurse and walker, with an oxygen tank rolling beside her

Noah is at the far end of the hall pretending he just happened to be there

AVA

Are you stalking me now?

NOAH

Doctor said you're not allowed to fall.

AVA

You're not allowed to hover

She takes three more steps with a smile

86 INT. HOSPITAL BATHROOM - AFTERNOON

86

Ava is standing by the sink looking into the mirror

She lifts her shirt slightly to see the scars

She traces the marks

87 INT. HOSPITAL HALLWAY - AFTERNOON

87

Noah is walking through the hall, slowly

His chest gets tight and his breathing slows

He braces himself against the wall

NOAH

Damn it

A nurse sees and goes up to him

NURSE 2

You need to take it easy

NOAH

I used to run for hours, easily

He slowly walks back to the hospital room

88 INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - NIGHT

88

Ava's asleep in her bed

Noah's sitting there alone

Claire is asleep in a chair

Noah tries to take a deep breath but struggles

He tries again, still struggling

NOAH
(whispering)
Come on.

He looks at the window and sees the reflection of Ava in her bed, breathing perfectly

He smiles and closes his eyes

89 INT. AVA'S HOUSE - AFTERNOON

89

Claire helping Ava up the stairs

She pauses half way

CLAIRE
You okay?

Ava nods

AVA
I don't feel like I'm drowning
anymore

90 EXT. FOOTBALL FIELD - AFTERNOON

90

Noah stands alone on the sideline

He looks onto the empty field

He walks to the line, gets into his stance

He starts trying to run, slow, unsteady

His breathing tightens and he slows down even more

He clutches his side

NOAH
(to himself)
Shit

He walks slowly back to the line, takes a second to rest
He starts trying to run again, his breathing is worse now
He holds his side again

NOAH (CONT'D)
(to himself)
I should be able to do this

He walks slowly to the bleachers and sits down
His head fills with the sounds of whistles and pads crashing together
He zones out for a bit, thinking about football
Mason comes over

MASON
Yo, Noah

NOAH
Hey, bro

Mason sits next to Noah

MASON
So... You donated your lung?

NOAH
Part of it.

MASON
You good?

NOAH
Yeah.

MASON
You sure?

Noah Shrugs

MASON (CONT'D)
You're allowed to be scared, you know

NOAH
I'm not scared, Just gonna miss
football. I probably won't play
again.

91 INT. NOAH'S KITCHEN - EVENING

91

Noah walks into the kitchen, out of breath
David sees him but says nothing at first
Noah sits down at the table and rests his head in his hands

NOAH
(under his breath)
This is so stupid

DAVID
I told you you'd regret it.

He looks up quickly

NOAH
I don't regret it.

DAVID
Then what's this about?

NOAH
I miss being able to run and
everything else, but that doesn't
mean I regret my choice.
(pause)
You would've done the same if it
was mom, right?

DAVID
Yes, I would. But that's different.
You two aren't even together

NOAH
I was going to ask her out right
before she passed out

DAVID
You were?

NOAH
Yeah, but now I just... I don't
know when to ask her.

DAVID

Son, if you're waiting for the perfect time to ask her, it's never going to happen. You just have to go for it.

92 INT. CLAIRE'S CAR ON THE WAY TO PT - AFTERNOON 92

Claire is driving

Ava's in the passenger seat

AVA

I hate this

CLAIRE

I know, but it'll be worth it.

AVA

I know that... But still

Claire parks the car

Helps Ava get out of the car

They walk into Physical Therapy slowly.

93 INT. PHYSICAL THERAPY OFFICE - AFTERNOON 93

Ava sits in the waiting room

Claire checks in

A few minutes later, DOCTOR HANNAH walks out

DOCTOR HANNAH

Ava Bennett?

Claire helps Ava up

They slowly walk back with Doctor Hannah

94 INT. CLAIRE'S CAR ON THE WAY HOME - AFTERNOON 94

Claire's driving

Ava's in the passenger seat holding her phone

AVA

Mom, don't you have work tomorrow?

CLAIRE
 I do. I can't call out again.
 (pause)
 Can you see if someone can take you
 tomorrow?

AVA
 I'll text Noah

CLAIRE
 Okay

Ava opens the messages app and goes to Noah's contact

AVA (TEXT)
 My mom has work tmr 🙄

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
 Can u take me to pt?

She waits a couple seconds

The typing bubble shows up

NOAH (TEXT)
 Yeah

NOAH (TEXT) (CONT'D)
 What time?

AVA (TEXT)
 12

NOAH (TEXT)
 Alr, see u then

Ava puts her phone away and stares out the window

95 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - EVENING

95

Ava's laying in bed

She swings her legs off slowly

She tries to stand, but falls to the ground

AVA
 Shit

She lays there on the floor

She puts her hands on her face and screams into them

AVA (CONT'D)
 This is so stupid! I should be able
 to stand!

She lays there a few seconds longer before pulling herself up
 on the bed

She manages to get into bed again

She lays there and starts quietly crying

Across the gap, Noah's light flips on and he looks over to
 Ava's room

Noah sees her on the bed crying and texts her

Her phone lights up and she checks it

NOAH (TEXT)
 U ok?

AVA (TEXT)
 I'm fine

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
 I tried to stand and couldn't

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
 Just being dramatic

NOAH (TEXT)
 Oh, ok

Ava glances at her clock and realizes it's 10:43PM

AVA (TEXT)
 It's late.

NOAH (TEXT)
 Yeah, ik

AVA (TEXT)
 Gn

NOAH (TEXT)
 Goodnight

96 INT. NOAH'S CAR ON THE WAY TO PT - AFTERNOON

96

Noah's driving

Ava's in the passenger seat

Noah parks in the parking lot

AVA
Thanks for bringing me

NOAH
You need help getting out?

AVA
I got it

Noah gets out of the car

After Ava gets out he tries to support her as they walk

AVA (CONT'D)
I said I got it

Despite her words, she leans slightly on him

NOAH
I know you do... I'm just making
sure you don't fall

AVA
You're the one we should be worried
about here

Noah pretends to stumble

NOAH
Yeah, definitely

Ava laughs

AVA
You're so stupid

They walk into the physical therapy office

97 INT. PHYSICAL THERAPY OFFICE - AFTERNOON

97

DOCTOR HANNAH
Ava! Come on in, we're ready for
you now

AVA
Thank you

Noah goes to sit down

AVA (CONT'D)
You can come too

Noah looks to Doctor Hannah

She gives him a nod

NOAH

Okay

Noah gets up and walks back with them

Doctor Hannah helps Ava hold onto a bar

She takes a few steps

She lets go of the bar and starts to wobble

DOCTOR HANNAH

Careful, don't let go if you're not ready

AVA

I know. I wish I was ready though

DOCTOR HANNAH

If your body's not ready, don't push it

AVA

Okay

Doctor Hannah helps Ava take a few more steps

98 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - AFTERNOON

98

The bedroom is empty

JULIA (O.S.)

Noah!

Julia walks into the room

She looks around and notices a paper by the window

JULIA (CONT'D)

Right... he took Ava to Physical Therapy

She walks over and picks up the paper and looks at it

She flips it over and it says "I think I'm falling for U"

She stares at it for a few seconds trying to understand

JULIA (CONT'D)

Ava

She lays it face up on Noah's bed and walks out of the room

99 INT. NOAH'S CAR ON THE WAY HOME - AFTERNOON

99

Noah's driving

Ava's in the passenger seat

NOAH

Good job

AVA

Don't.

NOAH

Don't what?

AVA

Don't lie

NOAH

But you did-

AVA

No, I fell like 5 times.

NOAH

Okay, do you want to talk about something else?

AVA

Can we just listen to the music?

NOAH

Yeah

He turns up the volume on the music a bit

100 EXT. STREET - EVENING

100

Noah pulls into his driveway

He gets out and helps Ava to her house

He opens the door for her and helps support her

101 INT. AVA'S LIVING ROOM - EVENING

101

She's struggling and tired

NOAH
You okay?

AVA
Yeah

He gives her a look

AVA (CONT'D)
Fine... No.

NOAH
You want to lay down?

AVA
Yes

Noah helps her to the steps

NOAH
One step at a time... Take it slow

Noah supports her as they walk up the steps

They go into Ava's bedroom

102 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - EVENING

102

Noah helps Ava get to her bed

AVA
Thank you for being patient with me
(pause)
And for putting up with my attitude
all the time

Noah laughs slightly at that

He rolls his eyes

NOAH
You're welcome

AVA
Don't roll your eyes at me!

He shakes his head slightly

NOAH

Do you want me to stay here for a
bit until your mom gets home?

AVA

Please.

Noah sits on the far edge of her bed

AVA (CONT'D)

Why are you all the way over there?

NOAH

I don't know

AVA

Come here

Noah moves closer to her

Ava leans into his side

He puts his arm around her

She puts hers around him

Silence for a few seconds

AVA (CONT'D)

You gave up everything. You gave up
your entire life, Noah

NOAH

I know... I made that choice

AVA

But I didn't... I wouldn't have
asked you to.

NOAH

Don't say that.

AVA

You didn't have to do this

NOAH

But I did... and I'd do it a
million times again.

AVA

What if you regret it?

(pause)

Like a year from now?

(MORE)

AVA (CONT'D)
 (pause)
 Or five?

NOAH
 I won't.

AVA
 You don't know that

NOAH
 Yes I do.

AVA
 How do you know?

NOAH
 Because I know what it would be
 like if I hadn't done it... And
 that's worse.

There's a long silence before she responds

She looks up at him

AVA
 I keep thinking this is all a dream
 and I'm gonna wake up and it's not
 real

NOAH
 I promise it's real

AVA
 You're different
 (pause)
 In a good way

NOAH
 So are you

103 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

103

Noah walks into the bedroom and sees the paper on his bed

He goes over and picks it up

He stares at the words "I think I'm falling for U"

He puts the paper in his desk drawer

He sits down on his bed

104 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

104

Ava is alone, laying in her bed

She's clearly been crying, but not anymore

Claire knocks softly, then opens the door

CLAIRE
Hey. Dinner's ready

AVA
I'm not hungry

Claire comes in fully and sits on the edge of the bed

CLAIRE
Talk to me

AVA
I stood for 7 seconds on my own
last week

CLAIRE
I remember, that was amazing

AVA
I fell five times today, mom

Claire stays quiet

AVA (CONT'D)
Five. And I couldn't get back up
either, Noah and Doctor Hannah had
to help me.
(pause)
What if this- What if I'm stuck
again? What if I can't stand for
more than 7 seconds?

CLAIRE
Ava-

AVA
Please give me a real answer, not
some bullshit reassurance that it's
all going to get better.

Claire tenses slightly, but maintains her composure

CLAIRE
I don't know... But... I do know
one thing

AVA

What?

CLAIRE

That you breathed a lot today
without having to think about it.

(pause)

You didn't notice that did you?

Ava thinks and her breathing is manual now

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

3 months ago you noticed... You
noticed every single breath didn't
you?

AVA

I did.

Claire squeezes her hand slightly

CLAIRE

Come eat. Even if it's just a
little

Ava holds onto Claire's hand to get up

Claire puts her arm around Ava

They walk together out of the room, slowly, shaky

105 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

105

Noah sits on his bed staring at the cork board

He gets up and takes them all down all the recruiting letters

He stacks them neatly on his desk

He puts his helmet from his desk onto the floor

He reaches into a drawer on his desk and pulls out a printed
photo of him and Ava in the hospital together as well as the
note from earlier

He pins those on the cork board instead and then goes back to
sit down

He stares at the photo and note, and his phone buzzes

He looks at the message

AVA (TEXT)
U awake?

NOAH (TEXT)
Yeah

AVA (TEXT)
Me too

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
Couldn't Sleep

NOAH (TEXT)
Same

AVA (TEXT)
Wyd?

NOAH (TEXT)
Nothing

NOAH (TEXT) (CONT'D)
Just thinking

AVA (TEXT)
Abt football?

NOAH (TEXT)
A little

AVA (TEXT)
Thats ok u know

NOAH (TEXT)
Ik

AVA (TEXT)
You're allowed to miss it

NOAH (TEXT)
I know

NOAH (TEXT) (CONT'D)
I don't regret it tho

AVA (TEXT)
I know you don't

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
That's what makes it more sad

He pauses and looks out the window to Ava's room

NOAH (TEXT)
I'm glad you're still here

AVA (TEXT)
Me too

AVA (TEXT) (CONT'D)
Goodnight

NOAH (TEXT)
Goodnight Ava

He puts his phone on the charger

He looks out the window, then turns off his lamp

106 INT. PHYSICAL THERAPY OFFICE - AFTERNOON

106

Ava sits down with Claire

Doctor Hannah comes into the room

DOCTOR HANNAH
Ava, come on back

Claire helps Ava stand and Doctor Hannah helps her walk back
Ava holds on to a rail in the hall

DOCTOR HANNAH (CONT'D)
I'm gonna let go of you now
(pause)
Hold on to the rail, and walk if
you can

AVA
Okay

Doctor Hannah lets go of Ava completely

Ava takes a few wobbly steps holding on to the rail, smiling

DOCTOR HANNAH
You're doing amazing! Keep going

Ava keeps walking slowly

DOCTOR HANNAH (CONT'D)
Okay, stop right there

Ava stops

AVA

Okay

DOCTOR HANNAH

Now try to let go of the rail...
I'll catch you if you fall

AVA

Okay

Ava lets go of the rail, and balances on her own, smiling

107

INT. RESTAURANT - EVENING

107

Noah, Mason, Emma, Nick, and Jess are all sitting together

Emma is across from Noah

MASON

How's Ava doing? With recovery?

Noah's face lights up slightly with the mention of Ava

Emma notices that and stays quiet

NOAH

She's getting better, figuring out
how to walk again

Mason also notices Noah's face and nudges him

MASON

You two should just make it
official already!

Everyone but Emma laughs

Emma forces a small laugh just a second later

EMMA

Yeah, what about you though. Have
you been able to run much?

Noah shrugs

NOAH

Some. Still getting back into it

Emma nods, paying more attention to his reactions than his
answer

EMMA

I saw you at the field, you looked good.

Noah smiles slightly, but not fully

NOAH

I barely made it 20 yards.

EMMA

Still. I thought it was good

Noah doesn't respond yet, and Emma notices his detachment

EMMA (CONT'D)

Are you okay? You seem off

NOAH

Still just tired.

EMMA

Right.

(pause)

Well... just don't forget who was here before you 'got tired'

Noah looks up quickly. The others all just watch quietly

NOAH

Emma.

Emma smiles quickly

EMMA

I'm kidding. Relax, Noah.

Noah looks around

NOAH

Okay, I need to go

Noah stands up and starts walking away

EMMA

I'll see you at the game, Friday?

NOAH

Maybe

Noah walks out of the restaurant

MASON

Thanks, Emma.

EMMA

Hey! It's not my fault

NICK

Yeah, It kinda is. You said 'got tired'

EMMA

So?

JESS

You don't remember what he said before?

EMMA

No, what?

JESS

That Ava's dad left because he 'got tired'

Emma's eyes widen slightly with realization

108 EXT. OUTSIDE RESTAURANT - EVENING

108

Noah stands by his car and stares at his phone

A text comes in. He checks it quickly

AVA (TEXT)

Can u still take me to pt tmr?

NOAH (TEXT)

Yeah

AVA (TEXT)

Thx, you're the best

Noah smiles at that

He reacts to that last message with a heart

Noah gets in his car

109 INT. NOAH'S CAR ON THE WAY TO PT - AFTERNOON

109

Noah's driving, quietly

Ava's staring out the window

Noah parks and Ava keeps staring out the window

NOAH

You okay?

Tears well up in her eyes

AVA

No. I'm not. I can't do this, Noah.

NOAH

Yes you can

Noah gets out and goes around to open her door

Ava leans toward him and he leans toward her

He puts his arms around her gently

She wraps her arms around him tight and holds on

NOAH (CONT'D)

I got you. It's okay

AVA

Don't let go

NOAH

I won't

They stay like that for a few seconds while she calms down

She wipes her tears and lets go of Noah

AVA

I think I'm ready

NOAH

Good, let's go

They walk into the physical therapy office

110 EXT. STREET - EVENING

110

Noah and Ava are walking together

Silence for a few seconds

AVA

Why'd you do it?

He doesn't answer right away

He looks down, then back to her

NOAH
I couldn't walk away.

AVA
You had everything

NOAH
Maybe... But it wouldn't have felt
like everything
(pause)
It would've felt like nothing
without you.

Ava's expression softens a bit

AVA
Dumbass.

NOAH
Yeah
(pause)
But I love you.

Ava doesn't respond right away

She looks at him, finally letting herself believe that

Her eyes well up slightly

AVA
I... I love you too. But you're
still a dumbass.
(pause)
My dumbass.

He holds her hand

She squeezes his hand tightly

NOAH
I was actually going to ask you
something before...

AVA
You mean before I almost died?

Noah lets out a small laugh

NOAH
Yeah, before that
(pause)
I was going to ask... would you
want to go out with me?

AVA
We're literally out right now.

NOAH
Yeah... I mean, like, officially.

AVA
(smiles)
Yes!

She squeezes his hand again

They keep walking and she pulls him down to kiss his cheek

He smiles and they keep walking

111 INT. NOAH'S KITCHEN - EVENING

111

David is standing by the sink drinking a glass of water

He glances out the window and sees Noah and Ava walking down the street holding hands, and laughing

He keeps looking for a while

Julia walks up behind him and hugs him from behind

Then she follows his gaze out the window

JULIA
When's the last time you saw him
this happy?

David takes a second to think before responding

DAVID
Not in a long time

112 EXT. TRACK - EARLY MORNING

112

Noah's alone stretching

He lines up

Starts jogging

Breathing heavily

He slows but doesn't stop

When he finally does stop, he checks his old time on his phone, then checks his new time

He deletes the old time and locks his phone

113 EXT. BLEACHERS - MORNING

113

Noah sits down on the bleachers breathing heavily

David walks up to the bleachers

NOAH

Dad? What are you doing here?

DAVID

Wanted to come see how you did...

(pause)

How'd it feel?

NOAH

Slow... Really slow

DAVID

Yeah

David sits on the step next to Noah

DAVID (CONT'D)

After my injury, I used to dream
every night that I was still
playing.

(pause)

And every time, I'd wake up feeling
like I lost everything

NOAH

Do you still?

DAVID

No... That all stopped when you got
into football

Noah doesn't respond yet

DAVID (CONT'D)

I was wrong at the hospital, before
the surgery

NOAH

Dad-

DAVID

I was wrong, son.

(pause)

What you did... That took more guts
than anything I've ever done.

Noah still stays quiet

David stands up and puts his hand on Noah's shoulder

DAVID (CONT'D)
Catch your breath and go to class.
I'm heading home

NOAH
Okay, bye Dad

David walks away, and waves back at Noah once

114 INT. AVA'S BATHROOM - MORNING

114

Ava standing in front of her mirror alone

Her hand lifts to her chest

She traces the surgical scar through her shirt

She takes a deep breath

115 EXT. BLEACHERS - AFTERNOON

115

Noah is on the bleachers

He takes a deep breath

Mason sits beside Noah on the bleachers

Emma is quietly watching from a distance

MASON
You're not playing anymore, man.
That's gotta be tough, huh?

NOAH
It is, but it's worth it

MASON
Ava must be a really special girl

NOAH
She is

MASON
So... are you two like... A thing
yet?

NOAH
Yeah, I asked her out last night

Emma's face drops, but she stays quiet and walks away

MASON

Congratulations, man! You two
should come to the football game
tomorrow. Should be a good one

NOAH

I'll ask her

116 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - AFTERNOON

116

Ava's laying in bed on her phone

CLAIRE (O.S.)

Ava! Come on downstairs! Lunch is
ready!

AVA

Okay! Coming!

Ava gets up and walks to her bedroom door to go downstairs

117 INT. AVA'S KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

117

Claire brings Ava a peanut butter and jelly and chips

CLAIRE

Here you go

AVA

Thanks

Ava starts eating the sandwich and chips

CLAIRE

Are you hanging out with Noah
today?

AVA

No he's staying late at school.
Said he wants to try to jog a
little bit or something.

CLAIRE

You better tell him not to push too
hard

AVA

He knows when to stop

CLAIRE
Okay... So how are you feeling
today?

AVA
Much better than before

CLAIRE
Good, you better be nice to that
boy. You owe him.

AVA
I know

118 INT. MORGANTOWN HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - AFTERNOON

118

Noah is walking slowly through the hall

Emma sees him and walks over

EMMA
Noah

NOAH
Oh, hi Emma. What's up?

EMMA
That was really nice of you. That
girl is lucky to have you

NOAH
Thanks

EMMA
I overheard you and Mason talking
earlier... Are you and Ava...
together?

NOAH
Yeah, we are.

Emma's face drops slightly for a second before she masks her
jealousy with a smile

EMMA
Oh... That's cool. Well I gotta
head to class, Bye.

NOAH
Bye

Emma walks to her class

Noah walks toward his and in the hall he passes Cole

Noah nods

Cole nods back

They both keep walking

119 EXT. TRACK - EVENING

119

Noah tries to run again

Coach Reynolds times him

He finishes, really slowly

COACH REYNOLDS
Different Body

Noah nods

COACH REYNOLDS (CONT'D)
Different race now

NOAH
Yeah

COACH REYNOLDS
You know you can't play football
anymore, right?

NOAH
I know

COACH REYNOLDS
But that doesn't mean you can't be
around the sport. There's plenty of
other options that would keep you
involved with football.

NOAH
Like what?

COACH REYNOLDS
Sports Medicine, Coaching the
younger receivers, and there's
other options too.

Noah nods slightly, considering it

120 INT. NOAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

120

Noah's laying in bed scrolling through his phone

He sees a post from a recruiting account with his face

The caption reads "Keep an eye on this one 🧐 "

He clicks on the account and scrolls through posts of other kids his age who still have these opportunities

His eyes drift to his desk where his old recruiting letters are stacked

He looks up slightly to the cork board and sees the picture of him and Ava

He looks back to his phone and unfollows the account and switches to the messages app

121 INT. AVA'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

121

Ava's sitting on the edge of her bed, on through her phone

A notification from Noah pops up

NOAH (TEXT)

There's a football game tmr night.
Want to go?

AVA (TEXT)

Do you want to?

NOAH (TEXT)

If u go

AVA (TEXT)

Ok then let's go

NOAH (TEXT)

It's at 6. Wanna leave around 5?

AVA (TEXT)

Ok yeah

NOAH (TEXT)

Ily

AVA (TEXT)

Say it

NOAH (TEXT)

Say what?

AVA (TEXT)
You know what

NOAH (TEXT)
I LOVE YOU

AVA (TEXT)
Much better, ily too

NOAH (TEXT)
Ur so mean

AVA (TEXT)


122 EXT. STREET - EVENING

122

Ava walks from her front door to Noah's driveway

Noah walks out of his house

NOAH
Ready?

AVA
Yeah, I've never been to a football
game in person before

NOAH
You're gonna love it

Noah opens the passenger door and Ava gets in

Noah goes to the driver's seat and starts driving

123 EXT. FOOTBALL FIELD - EVENING

123

Noah leads Ava to their seats, holding her hand

Travis and Kenzie are seated nearby

AVA
Wow, this is huge

NOAH
Yeah

They sit together and watch the teams warming up

Noah's phone buzzes

He check it and finds a message

RECRUITER (TEXT)

Hey, Noah. Please let us know if you're planning on joining our football program. We'd love to have you here! Reply STOP at any time to stop getting these texts.

Noah types back

NOAH (TEXT)

STOP

He deletes the message thread and locks his phone

He turns his attention back to the field

Ava leans her head on his shoulder and closes her eyes

Travis is laughing about something Kenzie said, then he notices Noah and Ava

He glances over at them, Kenzie follows his glance

Travis looks back away from Noah and Ava

Kenzie looks up to Travis

The ANNOUNCER starts the pre-game announcements

ANNOUNCER

Please stand for our National Anthem

Everyone stands up

Noah helps Ava stand slowly

The Star Spangled Banner starts playing

The players line the sidelines and everyone stays quiet for the song

Everyone sits down as the kicker sets up the tee

The referee raises his hand and blows the whistle

The kicker runs up and kicks the ball to start the game

124

INT. AVA'S ROOM - NIGHT

124

She stands by her window, without any help

Noah's in his room, they wave

Ava walks to her bed and gets her phone to call Noah

NOAH (V.O.)

Hey

AVA

Hi

NOAH (V.O.)

What are you doing in the morning?

AVA

Nothing yet... why?

NOAH (V.O.)

Do you want to go on a walk?

AVA

Yes, please. I need it

NOAH (V.O.)

Me too

(pause)

And maybe tomorrow night I can keep
my promise from before?

AVA

Which promise?

NOAH (V.O.)

The one about watching Harry Potter
outside together

AVA

You still want to do that?

NOAH (V.O.)

Yeah, of course I do

(pause)

Plus, it means I get to spend more
time with you

AVA

(teasingly)

Of course... you can't just do it
cause you actually want to watch it

Noah laughs slightly

NOAH (V.O.)

You're impossible

AVA

I know.

She looks through the window

Noah rolls his eyes playfully

NOAH (V.O.)
When do you want to go?

AVA
Eight?

NOAH (V.O.)
Eight. I'll be ready

AVA
Good, I love you

NOAH (V.O.)
I love you more. Goodnight

She smiles

AVA
Goodnight, Noah

She hangs up

Flops down on her bed, still smiling

She reaches over to her nightstand

Turns off the lamp

125 EXT. STREET - MORNING

125

Ava walks out of her front door without help

She goes to Noah's front door

She knocks on the door

Noah answers it

NOAH
Hey

AVA
Ready to go?

NOAH
Yeah, let's go

He comes outside

They start walking side by side
 Noah reaches for Ava's hand and intertwines their fingers
 Ava turns her head to look up at him
 She smiles as they keep walking

AVA
 Still the most boring street in
 America

NOAH
 It also still has potential

126 EXT. AVA'S BACKYARD - EVENING

126

Ava sitting cross-legged on a blanket on the grass
 Noah beside her
 Laptop buffering the movie plugged into the projector
 After a couple seconds the opening credits of Harry Potter
 and the Sorcerer's Stone begin
 She breathes evenly and looks at Noah

AVA
 You've really never seen this?

NOAH
 I've seen clips

AVA
 That doesn't count

On the projector the movie is playing
 Noah glances at her instead of the screen
 She notices and turns her head toward him

AVA (CONT'D)
 Watch the movie

NOAH
 I am

She breathes again as they scoot closer
 They hold eye contact and Ava's breathing changes slightly

Noah notices and looks down, then back to her eyes
 Ava leans closer and closes her eyes as she kisses Noah
 Noah's eyes widen for a half second before fluttering shut
 Noah's hand moves to cup Ava's cheek
 They kiss for a few seconds before she pulls back slightly
 They lean their foreheads against each other, smiling
 Ava giggles softly, turning to lay her head on his shoulder
 He turns back to the screen and wraps his arm around her
 She leaves her head on his shoulder while watching the movie
 Claire is in the kitchen watching them through the window
 She smiles and closes the blinds

CUT TO:

END CREDITS

CUT TO:

127 BLACK SCREEN

127

Ava and Noah's breathing together

AVA (V.O.)
 Still there?

NOAH (V.O.)
 Obviously.